The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2026

State cracks down on nursing home operators

In Taunton, arrival of inspectors triggers urgent messages to staff to make checks

By Neena Hagen and Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

In just the last two weeks, the state Department of Public Health has abruptly adopted a far more ag-

Spotlight FOLLOW-UP

gressive approach toward troubled nursing home operators, rejecting a California chain's bid to buy 11 facilities in Massachusetts and swarming another chain's homes with unannounced inspections after filing plans to revoke its 12 licenses.

The actions mark a striking shift for an agency that had not denied a nursing home license application or pulled an operator's license in at least seven years. They follow a Boston Globe Spotlight Team report, published on Sept. 28, that exposed lax state oversight of troubled out-of-state operators who have been on buying sprees in Massachusetts since the pandemic.

Sweetwater Care's application to permanently acquire 11 of 14 nursing homes, formerly operated by Next Step Healthcare, seemed headed for success. The Carlsbad, Calif., company, which was already managing the facilities under a receivership arrangement, even sent party hats for a planned celebration as they anticipated gaining a strong foothold in Massachusetts.

But on Tuesday, in what seemed an abrupt about-face, the state blocked Sweetwater's efforts to become a permanent operator of these homes that house about 1,000 residents. Regulators cited its history of serious safety violations and poor care in other states. In July, California authorities secured a $15 million settlement from Sweetwater and its affiliates over allegations of widespread understaffing and resident neglect.

Meanwhile, over the past week, state inspectors have been conducting regular, unannounced visits to nursing homes run by New Jersey businessman Eli Mirlis, whose chain, RegalCare, was the focus of the Globe report. He faces the loss of all 12 of its Massachusetts facilities due to the state's enforcement actions issued Oct. 13, and said then he plans to appeal.

NURSING HOMES, Page A9

'We're getting more applications than we have room to fill at any given time.'

MIRANDA DAY, *senior director of family and volunteer services at Children's*



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Levi Johnson-Griswell got crucial care at Boston Children's Hospital, and he and his parents had to stay in the city for months.

Scrambling for a place when life's at stake

Help's available for patients who need housing during treatment, but not enough

By Brianna Abbott
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Ron Griswell and Linea Johnson packed their car to the brim, buckled their newborn into his car seat, and drove more than 10 hours to reach the place they hoped could save him: Boston Children's Hospital.

Their son Levi had been born premature, and excess fluid in his brain had built up dangerous levels of pressure. His doctors near their home in North Carolina said they were out of options and recommended hospice. Instead, the family trekked to Massachusetts, hoping to get into the renowned hospital through its emergency department.

The plan worked. Doctors there said they could perform a procedure to relieve the pressure. Levi, they said, would likely face challenges, but ultimately he'd be OK.

To get the operation, however, the trio stayed in the city for months, bouncing between hotels, maxing out credit cards, and racking up debt. The procedure in May 2023 occurred weeks after the family arrived, and they stayed in Boston until that September as Levi recovered.

They are among the tens of thousands of families that come to Boston each year, seeking life-saving care. These families often stay for weeks or months, hunting to find affordable rooms in one of the country's most expensive cities.

Together, organizations in Boston offer more than 140 low-cost or free apartments or bedrooms set aside for patients. But the beds are often full, as added capacity at Boston hospitals, increasingly specialized procedures, and rural hospital closures have pushed more patients to travel for treatment. Now, several organizations are working to expand their housing and catch up with demand.

Griswell and Johnson navigated wait lists, hotels, and finding a safe space for Levi's weakened immune system, spending more than $20,000 on lodging alone. Then, they got connected with Hospitality Homes, which matches patients with host families or donated apartments. The nonprofit has seen more than a doubling of processed applica-

MEDICAL HOUSING, Page A8

Another round of layoffs at MGB

Second in under 2 years; 'difficult but necessary'

By Jonathan Saltzman and Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Mass General Brigham is the richest hospital system in Massachusetts, and yet for the second time in less than two years, it's making layoffs to boost its financial picture.

The nonprofit health care system, which employs over 80,000 workers, began laying off employees on Tuesday of last week, Jessica Pastore, an MGB spokesperson, said Thursday in an interview. She declined to say how many job cuts have taken place or how many are planned, but said that division and departments heads have been told to cut their budgets. She didn't specify by how much.

Among those affected are some pediatricians at Mass Eye and Ear, although they have been offered positions elsewhere in the system, MGB said.

"To strengthen our long-term financial sustainability, Mass General Brigham is continuing to make changes in how we operate," the health system said in a statement. "These are difficult but necessary decisions to ensure we can continue providing exceptional care for patients, advancing research and education, and investing in the people and programs that are central to our mission."

The cost-cutting comes about three years into the merging of clinical departments at MGB's two

MGB, Page A8

Cruise ships' crew targeted on child sex exploitation

Some concerns raised about lack of due process

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio and Shelley Murphy
GLOBE STAFF

It was the end of September, and the Norwegian Jewel, a 2,300-passenger cruise ship, was preparing to dock at Boston's Flynn Cruiseport. A crew member had been flagged about 75 times to a clearinghouse for tips related to child sexual exploitation, according to court filings.

Federal authorities were waiting. Customs and Border Protection officers searched him and two cellphones in his possession. They brought in agents from Homeland Security Investigations to help.

What authorities say they found was staggering.

The man, Bobby Prieto, a 35-year-old from the Philippines, allegedly had more than 1,200 media files containing child sexual abuse material on his two phones. When questioned by agents, Prieto al-

CREW MEMBERS, Page A9

Shining moments

Friday: Brisk, nice.
High 53-58. Low 37-42.

Saturday: Even better.
High 57-62. Low 39-44.

High tide: 9:36 a.m., 9:56 p.m.

Sunrise: 7:06 Sunset: 5:50

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

VOL. 310, NO. 115
*
Suggested retail price
$4.00

0 947725 42516

An mRNA cancer vaccine cut the risk of melanoma recurrence by 42 percent, according to a trial conducted by Moderna and Merck. **B5.**

The man who impregnated Sandra Birchmore testified she assured him Matthew Farwell was the father. **B1.**

The state Department of Transportation told Amazon it must obtain approval for its delivery drones after a public review process. **B5.**

Franklin Park Zoo's last lion was euthanized at age 17, suffering from a variety of issues. **B1.**

The original "Star Trek" is marking its 60th anniversary, a good time for our TV critic to list his favorite episodes. **G1.**

Israeli expatriates plan quick trips home to cast votes

By Brian MacQuarrie
GLOBE STAFF

Eitan Berechman, a 22-year-old college student from Newton, is determined to make a statement with his vote this year. The stakes are as high as they have ever been, Berechman said, and he cannot sit out this election.

All he had to do was book a flight to Israel.

Berechman is spending $2,000 to travel round-trip from Boston to vote in Israel's bitterly contested national election Tuesday, a pivotal referendum on Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's leadership after three years of war and upheaval.

A dual citizen of the United States and Israel, Berechman will have plenty of company. An estimated 50,000 Israeli citizens from overseas are expected to return from the United States and elsewhere to cast ballots, according to the American-Israel Democracy Coalition, a US-based nonpartisan organization.

In what is projected to be a tight race, the votes of Be-

ISRAELIS, Page A7



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

SHORT WEEK, LONG NIGHT FOR THE PATRIOTS — Back in action Thursday and facing the Chicago Bears just a few days after Sunday's win, New England stayed close but fell short, 30-24. **C1.**